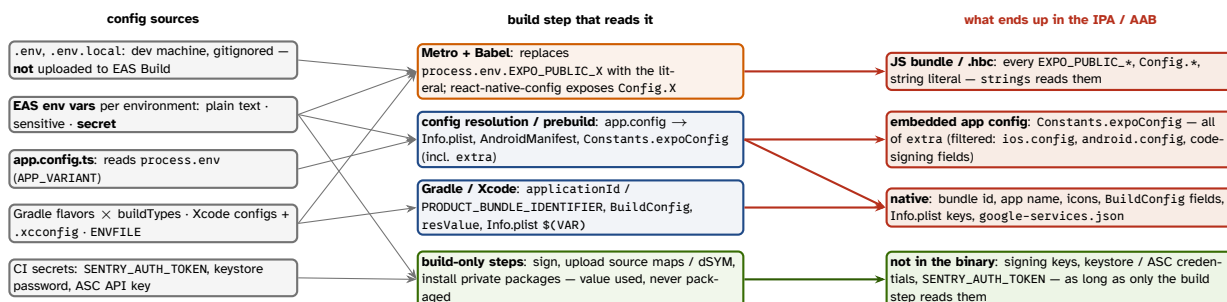


In one line: An **environment** (dev / staging / prod: API host, ids, keys) is chosen **at build time** — Android productFlavors, iOS configurations + schemes, or Expo's app.config + EAS environments. Every value that reaches JS or a native resource is **inside the binary**; only values read by *the build itself* (signing, uploads) stay secret.



Three words that get mixed up

environment = which backend + ids (dev/staging/prod) · **build type** = how it is built (debug: Metro, dev menu; release: bundled, minified, signed) · **variant** = flavor × build type (stagingRelease). Each environment gets its **own bundle id / applicationId**: installs side by side, separate push tokens, keychains, analytics and store/TestFlight tracks.

Android — productFlavors

```
android {
  buildFeatures { buildConfig true } // AGP 8: off by default
  flavorDimensions "env"
  productFlavors {
    staging { dimension "env"; applicationIdSuffix ".staging"
      resValue "string", "app_name", "Example S"
      buildConfigField "String", "API_HOST",
        '"https://api.staging.example.com"' }
    prod { dimension "env" }
  }
}
react { debuggableVariants = ["stagingDebug", "prodDebug"] }
// npx react-native run-android --mode stagingDebug
```

- debuggableVariants skip JS bundling (default debug, debugOptimized); with flavors you **must** list them, or those debug builds bundle JS too.
- Per-flavor files live in src/<flavor>/: google-services.json, icons, res/. --variant was replaced by --mode in the RN CLI (*unverified*).

iOS — configurations, schemes, xcconfig

- Project → Info: duplicate Release as Staging; each configuration gets an .xcconfig (PRODUCT_BUNDLE_IDENTIFIER, API_HOST, app icon name). A **scheme** per environment picks the configuration for Run / Archive.
- Info.plist <string>\$(API_HOST)</string> copies a build setting into the app — public, like everything in Info.plist.
- Podfile maps custom names: project 'App', 'Dev' => :debug — an unmapped configuration is built as :release (CocoaPods default).
- xcconfig treats // as a comment: https://x truncates to https: — write https://\$()/x (*unverified*).
- Per-env entitlements too: aps-environment, associated domains, App Group ids.

Expo — one codebase, many variants

```
// app.config.ts - evaluated at build/prebuild, NOT at runtime
import { ExpoConfig, ConfigContext } from 'expo/config';
const V = process.env.APP_VARIANT ?? 'production';
const id = V === 'production' ? 'com.example.app'
  : 'com.example.app.${V}';

export default ({ config }: ConfigContext): ExpoConfig => ({
  ...config, name: V === 'production' ? 'Example' : 'Example ${V}',
  ios: { ...config.ios, bundleIdentifier: id },
  android: { ...config.android, package: id },
});
// eas.json build.preview: { "environment": "preview",
//   "env": { "APP_VARIANT": "preview", "channel": "preview" }
```

- EXPO_PUBLIC_* is **inlined at bundle time**, and only for static dot access process.env.EXPO_PUBLIC_API_URL — bracket access or destructuring stays undefined. A change needs a new bundle (restart Metro, clear its cache).
- EAS environment variables:** plain text (visible everywhere) · sensitive (masked in logs) · **secret** (never readable outside EAS servers). A build picks them via "environment" in eas.json; eas env:pull --environment development writes .env.local; eas update --environment production — or the update is bundled with your *local* values.
- react-native-config:** .env → Config.API_URL (JS), BuildConfig (Android), \$(VAR) in Info.plist; ENVFILE=.env.staging. Its README: it does *not* obfuscate or encrypt — no sensitive keys in .env.

Public or secret?

fine in the app	never in the app
API base URL, Sentry DSN, Stripe pk_, Firebase config, Maps key <i>restricted</i> to your ids, flag defaults	Stripe sk_, LLM / payment / DB keys, signing keys, keystore + ASC credentials, SENTRY_AUTH_TOKEN

Values that must change without a build (limits, kill switches) come from the server: remote config / flags, per environment.

Traps

- ! "It's an EAS *secret*" — public once exposed to JS or extra.
- ! const { EXPO_PUBLIC_URL } = process.env → undefined.
- ! OTA update without --environment: prod app talks to staging.
- ! One bundle id for staging + prod: overwrites, crossed push tokens.

Remember

Chosen at build · baked into the binary · only the build keeps a secret.

Related: rn-app-security (who reads the bundle) · rn-tooling-release (EAS, channels, OTA) · signing-and-cicd · linking-and-launch-time (xcconfig) · flags-experiments-observability (remote config)